

| By Nirmala Ravindran |

It's a nondescript hotel called Basant Residency. Opposite a Jain temple in Bangalore's busy Gandhinagar, it opens into a street filled with hawkers and shops selling automobile parts and pirated DVDs. It's also where acclaimed director Girish Kasaravalli, who is third only to Satyajit Ray (six) and Buddhadeb Dasgupta (five) when it comes to National Award winning films, announces his next film, *Kanasemba Kudureya Benneri*, which translates to 'Atop a Dream Horse'. Clad in a trademark kurta and beige trousers, the director who has been riding a dream horse in the world of alternative cinema for over three decades, is besieged by phone calls from aspiring youngsters who want to work with him as assistants or actors. He takes each call with a gentle 'namaskara', because the concept of a secretary or manager is as alien to him as the idea of flash—he still drives his own car, a modest Maruti Esteem.

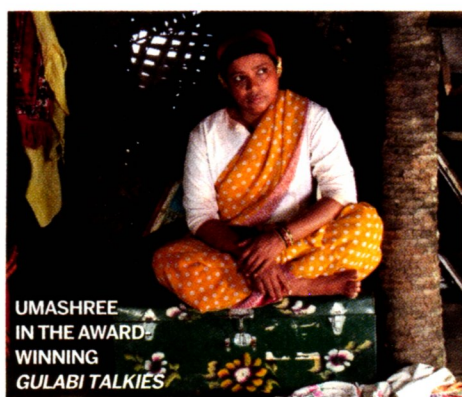
Though not too many people outside the world of what is today called 'meaningful cinema' have heard of the 59-year-old director, the announcement of the annual National Film Awards is the time when Kasaravalli's team rejoices as it invariably wins accolades and is suddenly in the spotlight. "This year the south has swept the awards which is why the National Awards have been largely ignored by the national media. There is an 'our cinema' and 'their cinema' as far as Bollywood is concerned," he says, unperturbed like most people who have understood the system.

This year, actress Umashree won the Best Actress Award for her role in *Gulabi Talkies* (2008) directed by him. Umashree, 52, veteran of more than 300 Kannada films, says she had to unlearn everything she knew about cinema to essay the role of a rural Muslim woman, a midwife, abandoned by her husband whose only love affair is with the cinema. "It was like a whole new school of acting for me," gushes the actress who also won the Karnataka State award for best actress as well as the Best Actress Award at the Osian's Cinefan Festival. While the Indian film industry wakes up to the genius of Kasaravalli only when it comes to winning awards, the Film Archive of Paris selected *Ghattashraddha* (1977), his debut film after he graduated from the Film and Television Institute of India (FTII), for the hundredth anniversary celebrations of cinema as one of the best 100 films in the world in 2002. It was the only film from India.

But international honours are not a rarity for him. The London Film Festival this year will showcase a Kasaravalli retrospective. "Girish is a very important filmmaker for

India. I think his *Thayi Saheba* (1997) is one of the finest films; I loved the way it talked about the transition in Indian society," says Adoor Gopalakrishnan. It's a mutual admiration society. "I have always considered Ray and Adoor the best India has produced," Kasaravalli says. Accolades and recognition apart, Kasaravalli insists that it's hard work raising funds for the kind of films he wants to make. "We don't have an alternative distribution system like Europe. Nor do we have theatres that screen art house cinema, except in Kerala. It's a constant fight against the system," says the man who has made only 11 films in a career spanning 35 years.

Not too many people remember that he made a hugely forgettable film in Hindi, *Ek Ghar* (1989) with Naseeruddin Shah, Deepti Naval and Rohini Hattangadi. "Making a Kannada film, *Mane*, with non-Kannada actors was a mistake. We simultaneously shot it in Hindi as well. It's not an experience I care to repeat," he insists. Kasaravalli is an auteur in the real sense of the word and is involved from writing the script to framing the scene. "I take nearly two years to write the script and screenplay before I commence work, which is why my films take long to make." Budding director, actor and his daughter Ananya testifies



to his being a stickler for perfection. "He's cast me only in one film because he felt I suited the role. He gives all his actors the space and time to grow and ensures that they deliver what he's visualised," she says. Kasaravalli, best known for his use of location, be it the beautiful Malnad region in *Dweepa* (2002) in the torrential monsoons or the landscape in *Nayi Neralu* (2006), is one of the few directors who have never shot in an artificially created set. "Location plays a very important

part in my films. I rewrite after I finalise the location. The story takes twists and turns based on it."

His next film, *Kanasemba...*, starring Umashree is based on a short story by Amaresh Nugadoni. He has always veered towards published texts, both novels and short stories for his films, be it U.R. Ananthamurthy's *Ghattashraddha* or Poornachandra Tejaswi's *Tabarana Kathe* which won the National Award in 1988 or a novel by S.L. Byrappa, *Nayi Neralu*. As a young boy, he grew up in the Malnad region watching Yakshagana performances (he later made a film *Bannada Vesha* on the real story of a Yakshagana performer). "It was by chance that I opened the paper one morning and saw the application for FTII. I had a seat for M.Pharma in Udupi waiting for me when I decided to apply. I knew nothing about films and had only seen about 25 films till then. If not a filmmaker, I would definitely have become a pharmacist," he says. Fortunately for his audience, that choice doesn't exist anymore. ■